

Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

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SEARCH



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Use A Toolbar

Don't bother going to Google's homepage by typing in www.google.com every time you want to search. Don't even set your homepage to Google—it takes up a couple of seconds, which add up! Use the Google toolbar—it comes inbuilt in Firefox and Opera, and for Internet Explorer, head to toolbar.google.com for the small download. For the Yahoo! search toolbar, visit toolbar.yahoo.com.

Filtering Search Results

Google and Yahoo! don't have parental controls, but you can control what you yourself are exposed to! If you don't want obscene images turning up in an image search, for example, set your Google preferences to "Use strict

filtering." The Google preferences link is to the right of the search bar on www.google.com.

Excluding Unwanted Results #1

The "-" (minus) sign is used to exclude certain words from your search. If you want to search for information about 5.1 speaker sets, you'll probably get a lot of results that speak about other speaker configurations. Instead of "5.1 speakers", try "5.1 speakers -2.1 -4.1 -6.1 -7.1".

The Use Of Quotes

Use quotes as often as possible for the most relevant results, and for your desired results to appear as high up in the list as possible. For example, if you want to know who the Time Man of the Year for 1990 was, it's better to type in "time's man of the year" with the quotes, followed by "1990" (with or without the quotes), rather than just "time's man of the year 1990" without any quotes. Check it out!

Using The "Cached" Feature

If a result link is taking too long to open, and the information you need doesn't relate to time (as in news items), use the "cached" link (if there is one) after the result. This will almost certainly load, since Google and Yahoo! are almost never down!

Personalised Search

If you want your search results to become more and more relevant over time, and if you don't mind Google knowing a lot about you, sign in before you search. The sign-in link is at the top right corner of the Google homepage,

and you'll need to use your Gmail username and password. From then on until you sign out, Google remembers what you searched for and what you clicked, making it possible to give you more accurate, personalised results.

Some may be paranoid about Google knowing so much about you, but in some peoples' opinion, "Who cares what a server in California or somewhere knows about me?" It's your choice...

Forget The Dictionaries

Google can replace several other kinds of searches. If you want to know what the time in New York is just now, just type in "New York time"! Similarly, if you need to know the difference in usage (or use?) between the words "usage" and "use," you don't need to go to an online thesaurus or dictionary. Simply type in "use usage" into Google, and you'll get results directly from dictionaries and thesauri! Note that in this particular example, Google does the job for you, but Yahoo! doesn't. MSN brings up the required result second, which is quite nearly there.

Force Keywords

Not all words in a search string come up in search results. You'll sometimes find that somewhere down in the results, there are pages which don't contain one or more of your search terms at all! This is especially true for searches with many keywords. It suffices to say that it's Google's way of giving you the most relevant results. To force a certain keyword or keyphrase to be included in the search, use the "+" sign. For example, typing in "favourite example hardware sata mouse" (without the quotes) will bring up some results without one or more of those words. If you need the word "example" (which is a common word, so Google might leave it out), type "favourite +example sata hardware mouse".

Excluding Unwanted Results #2

To exclude irrelevant results, try using extra keywords. For example, if you want information on various fruits, such as apples, grapes and mangoes, you might key in these words into, say, Yahoo! You'll see results that include lots and lots of fruits. Take a few of those from the first couple of results and exclude them using a minus sign.

For example, "apples grapes mangoes" (without the quotes) brings up 84,000 results on Yahoo, with lots of irrelevant fruits mentioned. Now, type in "apples grapes mangoes -bananas -pears -plums -lemons -oranges -pineapples". Voila—just 1,100 results! Of course, this is just an example of how you can drastically trim down your results.